but the understanding of the landscape. For two decades, the US struggled with the paradox that the very country that was fuelling the fighting against it was also the one critical for its logistics. The dilemma was so acute that even the presence of Osama bin Laden in Pakistan could not bring it to head. This should not take away from the dexterity with which those cards were played by the Pakistani military, leaving a generation of American military and political leaders with scrambled identification, friend or foe (IFF) systems!

Today, however, the world contemplates the opposite quandary. It desperately hopes that irrespective of developments within the Afghan society, there would be no negative external implications. Some countries define that in terms of terrorism and radicalization. Others are more concerned at the possibility of refugee outflow or treatment of women. Whatever happens, the truth is that international relations continue to grapple unsatisfactorily with the problem of reconciling sharply divergent cultures in a more tightly integrated world.

THE ARRIVAL OF 'OTHERS'

Some of the frictional aspects of the current situation have spawned their own discourse on how best to advance interests. In an effort to correct the outcomes of a less strategic era, there has been a debate about the virtues and viability of de-coupling. Like most other concepts, it is sensible to avoid extreme interpretations.

The global economy is today far too interlinked for it to be nationally separated in a comprehensive way. No society can really afford to see that happen, which is why it will not. At the same time, there is open talk of strategic competition that cannot be wished away either. Competitors clearly are not going to trust each other beyond a point. Any two-way link, be it trade, resources, connectivity or pipelines, will normally be better leveraged by the harder state or the one smart enough to have anticipated it. The very openness that drives creativity and progress also becomes a vulnerability. The likely repercussions of such attitudes will be to encourage autonomy and safeguarding in selected areas and, at the same time, to try and develop redundancy and reliability wherever necessary in other domains. This also leads to a renewed focus on export controls and technology sharing. Chips and semiconductors are an obvious example.